

Interested in Uplift?

Here's what Fall 2026 has in store.

TechUnited:NJ's founder mentorship program

Eight weeks to make real progress

September 9 to November 6, 2026

Who we are: **TechUnited:NJ.**

New Jersey's leading tech and startup community.

- Founded to champion NJ as a home for founders and investors
- Creators of **Propelify**, the Northeast's flagship innovation festival
- Drove the recent law to recognize QSBS in New Jersey
- We serve the full cycle of startups, from individual founders to small and medium-sized businesses, all the way to large companies and enterprise

30K

community members

200+

member companies

300K

employees represented

"Thankful to be in rooms where we are heard and lifted."

• **Lina Escobar**, Owner, Sweet Aurora Co. (Edison cohort)

What is **Uplift**?

An 8-week accelerator program for early-stage founders based in New Jersey, built around mentorship, peer community, and the focused work of moving your company forward.

Open to founders at any stage

Idea to revenue-generating. Solo founders to small teams.

Focused on supporting

Women and minority founders building the future of NJ.

Two layers of support

Matched mentors bring 1:1 expertise.

Cohorts bring peer community.

Our mission

Empower entrepreneurs and innovators to build a better future for all.

MADE POSSIBLE BY

Our partners.

This program exists because the state believes in you.

NJEDA

New Jersey Economic Development Authority

Supporting startups and small businesses across the state of New Jersey.

NJ DOS

New Jersey Department of State

Backing innovation and entrepreneurship as engines of New Jersey's future.

A snapshot of Uplift Fall 2026.

From every corner of New Jersey, building across every sector.

76

founders enrolled

5

blended cohorts

13

NJ counties

PLACEHOLDER: PREVIOUS PROGRAM STATS

INDUSTRIES IN THE ROOM



WHAT WE'RE WORKING ON



WHERE WE'RE BASED



From the shore to the Skylands.

Idea-stage to revenue-generating. Solo founders to small teams.

Uplift cohorts.

Each named after a New Jersey innovator whose legacy reflects the cohort's character.

COHORT 1

Edison

WHO LANDS HERE

Customer-chasers.

Go-to-market, ship-and-iterate energy.

"It was incredible to have so many able founders, mentors, the mayor, NJEDA and other exceptional individuals in the room."

• **Harshil Thakkar**, Edison cohort alumni

16 founders

(placeholder, Fall count TBD)

COHORT 2

Hopper

WHO LANDS HERE

The builders.

Enterprise SaaS and MVP-stage builders.

"I didn't know what to expect with this, and I'm so excited... sounds like a lot of people here have a great story, too."

• **Pearl Gabel**, Hopper cohort alumni

15 founders

(placeholder, Fall count TBD)

COHORT 3

Bardeen

WHO LANDS HERE

The technical cohort.

AI / Data / ML founders.

"More people in your corner' is real. Grateful to be building alongside this group."

• **Stephanie Scott-Bradshaw**, Bardeen cohort alumni

15 founders

(placeholder, Fall count TBD)

COHORT 4

Lawrence

WHO LANDS HERE

Inflection-point founders.

Fundraising, pivots, and major launches.

"The Uplift Mentorship Program... is built for the founders who've historically been overlooked... this is what community is supposed to feel like."

• **Debbie Douglas-Henry**, Lawrence cohort alumni

15 founders

(placeholder, Fall count TBD)

COHORT 5

Morrison

WHO LANDS HERE

The clarity-seekers.

Clarity, priorities, and finding your voice.

"I would HIGHLY support a regular monthly alumni meeting. I can't begin to express the gratitude I have for this program."

• **Rachel Hayes**, Morrison cohort alumni

15 founders

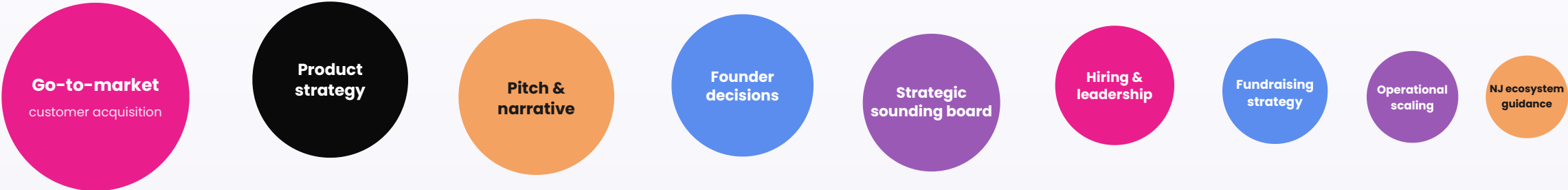
(placeholder, Fall count TBD)

A snapshot of your mentor talent pool.

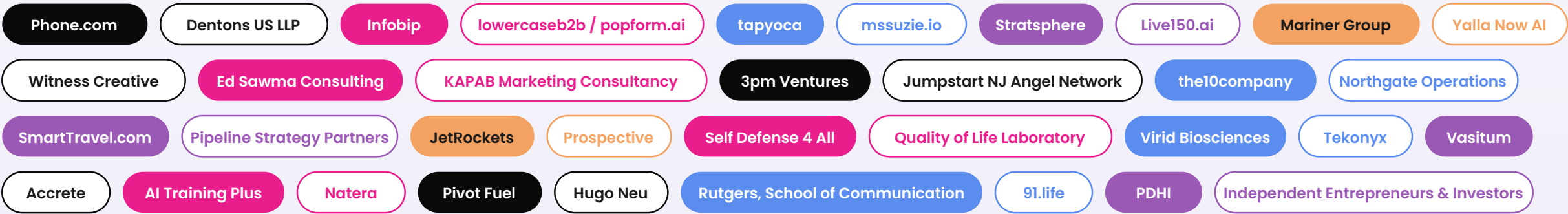
Operators, founders, and investors with deep New Jersey roots.

PLACEHOLDER: PREVIOUS PROGRAM STATS

EXPERTISE



COMPANIES REPRESENTED



Why mentors **show up.**

Mentoring through Uplift is a volunteer role, done to give back to the community and strengthen the ecosystem. But it goes both ways; your mentor gets something real out of it too.

"I want to bring practical, in-the-trenches marketing and brand-building guidance, and the candid feedback founders say is hardest to find elsewhere."

On what she hopes to get: "Staying close to the real, current challenges founders face, and connecting with other operators and investors in the Uplift network."

• **Jeanne McPhillips, Founder, SuperGirls LLC**

"Guide entrepreneurs in their journey to a successful business."

On what he hopes to get: "The satisfaction of giving back, and networking."

• **Jay Dave, Founder & COO, Vortalsoft**

"I believe I will be able to get much more from the outstanding founders here than I would be able to give."

• **Jessie Lee, GTM, SmartTravel.com**

WHAT IT GIVES BACK TO THEM

Paying it forward

someone did this for them once

Staying sharp

fresh problems keep them close to the ground

A community, not a transaction

other operators and investors in the room

Front-row seats

to what NJ founders are building next

How your mentor is meant to support you.

There are a million ways a stranger with more experience can help you. That's the whole point.

What they might do

- Open up their network
- Share advice, and the anecdotes behind it
- Tell you what worked, and what didn't, for them
- Nudge you toward a resource or direction worth trying, and just as often, one that isn't
- Just listen, as a sounding board

What mentorship isn't

- Building your product, or doing the work for you
- A consultant, or a coach paid to always cheer you on
- Someone who's lived your exact scenario in your exact industry, their edge is usually adjacent, and that still counts
- Guaranteed answers on demand
- A job. Mentors volunteer their time, same as you'd hope someone would for you

What your mentor will know about you.

Your mentor gets your company at a glance before your first meeting, pulled straight from your application. Your cohort-mates can see it too, in the Cohort Directory. One exception: your revenue dollar range stays between you and your mentor.

MY COMPANY AT A GLANCE

Close

Kennedy Inc · CEO

"Highly curated thought provoking dinners in your home."

Stage	MVP / Early build
Industry	CPG / Consumer Brands
Revenue (last 12 months)	Pre-revenue
Generating revenue	No
Employees	No
Hiring	No
Raising capital	No
Previously raised outside capital	No
Looking for customers or pilots	Yes
Seeking strategic partnerships	Yes
Based in	Hoboken, Atlantic County
Founder journey	Emerging Founder, Exploring an idea and preparing to start a company

HOPING TO ACCOMPLISH

I'm hoping to accomplish clarity in my go-to-market strategy

WHAT YOU WANT FROM MENTORSHIP

I would just like a sounding board, someone to ask real honest questions to whether that's about business confidence, how they knew when they had a winning idea, what to do, what to do next, looking for that.

From your application, submitted 2026-08-25. Something changed? Tell us at uplift@techunited.co and we'll update it.

How your match is actually made

A matching tool built for this program scores every founder-mentor pair on five factors: **time-commitment fit, focus-area alignment, your own words vs what they offer, stage fit, and schedule overlap**. Then a person on our team confirms every match. Nothing is auto-assigned.

BEST MENTORS FOR THIS FOUNDER		
Perfect match score 12	sessions aligned (both 4-6) · focus: go-to-market, fundraising, strategy · shared language: investor, founder · 4-6 sessions	Match
Perfect match score 11	3 MENTEES sessions aligned (both 4-6) · focus: go-to-market · shared language: market, strategy, honest · stage fit · schedule works · 4-6 sessions	Match
Excellent match score 9	sessions aligned (both 4-6) · focus: fundraising, strategy · schedule works · 4-6 sessions	Match
Excellent match score 9	mentor offers more sessions than asked · focus: go-to-market, product · shared language: founder, things, stage · schedule works · 7-10 sessions	Match
Excellent match score 8	sessions aligned (both 4-6) · focus: go-to-market · shared language: connections · schedule works · 4-6 sessions	Match
Strong match score 6	sessions aligned (both 4-6) · focus: go-to-market · 4-6 sessions	Match

The actual tool: one founder's ranked shortlist, names and companies blurred. Full write-up in Resources: **How We Match Founders & Mentors.**

Program expectations over the next eight weeks.

EDUCATIONAL SESSIONS

- ✓ **3 sessions minimum, any combo**
Mon 12:30–1, Tue 5:30–6, Fri 12:30–1 · choose whichever fit you

- ✓ **At least 1 of your 3 done by Oct 1**

“The Elevator Pitch exercise was super cool. Being put on the spot was actually a good thing; we weren’t overly prepared.”

• **Pierre Girgis**, *Lawrence cohort*

MENTOR TIME

3 meetings, 3 hours: Discover → Act → Roadmap.

- ✓ **Discover**
Meeting 1 · within 7 days of being matched
- ✓ **Act**
Meeting 2 · within 10 days of Meeting 1
- ✓ **Roadmap**
Meeting 3 · suggested by Oct 23

IN-PERSON: OVERDRIVE AI

Your In-Person Event. Required, no exceptions.

- ✓ **October 27, 2026**
TechUnited’s marquee event
- ✓ **Bring the mission from your Roadmap**

COMMUNICATION SLA

Reply within 72 hours to your PM, TechUnited, your mentee, or your mentor (OOO/vacation notices excepted).

WEEKLY PULSE CHECK

10 seconds in your portal, opens and closes every Friday. **Green:** A-okay. **Yellow:** check in soon. **Red:** not going as planned.

SUBMIT YOUR MEETINGS

A portal link per meeting: date, length, notes (AI note-taker or your own). Takes a minute.

SIGN YOUR PAPERWORK

At program end, verify by signature that your logged sessions and meetings are accurate. Clean logs, a two-minute task.

Sessions must be attended live, and we track registration and attendance for you.

THREE SESSIONS, THROUGHOUT THE PROGRAM

Educational sessions: **show up, get sharper.**

30 minutes, live, offered Mon / Tue / Fri every week. You're required to complete 3 throughout the program, pick whichever fit your schedule, with at least 1 done by Oct 1.

MONDAY

12:30 – 1:00 PM

TUESDAY

5:30 – 6:15 PM

FRIDAY

12:30 – 1:00 PM

THREE FORMATS, ROTATING ACROSS ALL THREE TIME SLOTS. ANY FORMAT CAN LAND ON ANY DAY.

EXPERT INSIGHT

A practitioner breaks down a real skill: fundraising, GTM, positioning, whatever's next for you.

INDUSTRY Q&A

Open floor with someone further down the path. Bring your real, specific questions.

PEER DEVELOPMENT

Structured time with other founders in your cohort, working through the same stage.

RSVP ON LUMA

Every session, speaker, and date lives on TechUnited's Luma page and in your portal. Save it, register in advance. **Register on Luma with your Uplift ID** so we can properly map your attendance.

ATTENDANCE IS TRACKED

Sessions must be attended live, we track your registration and attendance for you (that's why registrations need your Uplift ID). You confirm it at program end. Miss one? Nothing covers it, there's no makeup.

How to structure your one-on-one meetings: **Discover, Act, Roadmap.**

Whatever session count you signed up for, here's the suggested arc. Each meeting does its own job.

MEETING 1 · WITHIN 7 DAYS OF MATCH

Discover

THE JOB: Context and trust. Pick the problem worth your hours together.

BRING

- Your goals reflection from the portal
- Where the company actually is: traction, runway, blockers
- The one decision you keep circling

LEAVE WITH

- One focus area you both agree matters most
- What winning looks like by November
- Your next meeting on the calendar

MEETING 2 · WITHIN 10 DAYS OF MEETING 1

Act

THE JOB: Turn Discover into a move. Advice becomes action here.

BRING

- What you tried since your previous meeting, including what flopped
- Real numbers, real customer conversations
- The obstacle that surprised you

LEAVE WITH

- One concrete commitment with a date on it
- An experiment, a decision, or an intro your mentor can make
- What to measure before your next meeting

MEETING 3 · SUGGESTED BY OCT 23

Roadmap

THE JOB: Zoom out. Agree on the long-term plan and how you'll keep meeting.

BRING

- Results from your Act commitment
- An honest read on what's changed since your Discover meeting
- Your biggest open question for the next quarter

LEAVE WITH

- Your next three moves, in order
- The signals that tell you it's working
- Whether you're meeting again, and how often

4-6 MEETINGS

Discover Act Roadmap Act Act

7-10 MEETINGS

Discover Act Roadmap Act Act Act Act

These three meetings should launch you into Overdrive. (Get it. We love dad jokes here.)

Uplift at **OverdriveAI.**

OVERDRIVEAI

TechUnited's marquee event. This is why Discover, Act, and Roadmap come first.

A GOOD KIND OF UNCOMFORTABLE

Growth is a pressure test. OverdriveAI is your chance to show up a little uncomfortable, on purpose, and put your work in front of people before it feels ready. Share the ugly baby. That's how it grows up.

This sets you up for success in the second half of your program, as you dive deeper with your educational sessions and your mentorship.

OCTOBER 27, 2026 · REQUIRED

By Oct 27 you'll walk in with a mission from your Roadmap. Use OverdriveAI as rocket fuel for it:

Meet more people

Sell more things

Practice your CTA

Practice your pitch

All things future of AI, future of tech, future of New Jersey, and a room full of the exact people who can move your mission forward.

Log your mentorship meetings as you go.

We verify mentor hours at the end of the program, so an easy log keeps things smooth.

Why we ask

- Helps confirm your 3 hours of 1:1 mentor time
- Gives your mentor what they need to sign off at program end
- Captures takeaways so progress is easy to see
- **Submit with your Uplift ID**, it's how your meetings map to you

REQUIRED: AI NOTE-TAKER

- ☒ **Granola** (preferred)
- ☒ **Fathom**
- ☒ **Otter**

An AI notetaker that runs alongside your calls so you don't have to take notes manually, and gives us a clean record to verify your sessions. Be explicit with your mentor about which tool you're using. If you opt out, you're responsible for your own written notes.

Have yours set up before your first mentor meeting.

Your 8-week **journey** at a glance.

ONBOARDING · SEPT 9–13

Orientation · portal access

Goals reflection · RSVP OverdriveAI · set up your AI note-taker

WEEK 1 · SEPT 14–20

Mentor match · Discover

Meeting 1, due within 7 days of your match

WEEK 2 · SEPT 21–27

Act

Meeting 2, due within 10 days of Meeting 1 · edu sessions run Mon / Tue / Fri

WEEKS 3–5 · SEPT 28–OCT 25

Deep Work · Roadmap

Weekly sessions + pulse checks · 1st edu session by Oct 1 · Meeting 3 by Oct 23

WEEK 6 · OCT 26–NOV 1

★ OverdriveAI, Oct 27

Your required in-person · we showcase you to the community

WEEK 7 · NOV 2–6

Final stretch

Close out 3 meetings + 3 sessions · end report due

WEEKS 8–9 · NOV 7–20

Completion & documentation

Exit survey + signature verification · certificate lands in your portal

How you'll hear from us.

EDUCATIONAL SESSIONS: LUMA + PORTAL

All dates, RSVPs, and speakers live in Luma and stay updated there. Your portal points you to it. Luma and your portal together are your source of truth.

IF YOU MISS A PULSE CHECK

You'll hear from your PM directly if you skip one, just a quick check-in. Complete it and we assume you're good; no news is good news.

A WEEKLY EMAIL, TUESDAY MORNINGS

A quick recap: what happened last week, what's happening this week, which sessions are available, and a reminder of where you should be. That's it.

AUTOMATED PORTAL MESSAGES

Some emails come straight from your portal, marked  and clearly automated. They fire on logic alone: something you did in the portal, or our review of your materials clearing. They are receipts, not personal outreach, and a human reads every reply.

One thing that's on you: staying connected to your mentor is your responsibility. We'll support you, but Discover, Act, and Roadmap only work if you drive them.

Portal demo.

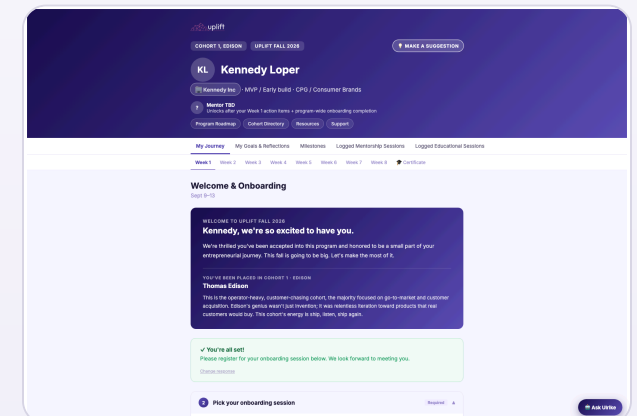
Everything you can do inside the portal. Let's do a live walkthrough.

Get oriented

- How to log in
- Find your cohort
- See your cohort-mates
- **Program resources →**
- **How we match founders & mentors →**

Stay engaged

- Make sure TechUnited's Luma page is saved
- Register in advance for the sessions you're attending
- Plan out your mentor meetings on the calendar now



MEET YOUR PORTAL BOT

Say hi to Ulrike.

"I know this program inside and out, and impressively little else." That's Ulrike's own introduction, and it's the whole idea.

Ask her about

- Program requirements and deadlines
- How to structure your mentor meetings
- Where to find a resource or document
- How to sign out: exit survey, signature, certificate

Why use her

- Faster than digging through Resources or emailing us
- Available right in your portal, anytime
- Doesn't know anything outside the program, on purpose



The real Ulrike · 102 · NYC

Why "Ulrike"? Ask her yourself; she tells the story better than a slide could. →

Anything she can't answer routes straight to uplift@techunited.co.

 **Ulrike · Uplift Chat Bot** —

Automated. Knows the program, your progress, and impressively little else.

Ulrike, who are you?

I'm Ulrike, your built-in helper here in the portal, named after a real 102-year-old New Yorker who's sharper and more agile than people half her age. She's spry, direct, no-nonsense warm, and more mighty than she looks, which felt like the right vibe for a chat bot. I'm here to answer your questions about the program, your progress, and what comes next, all from what I actually know. Ask away.

Ask about the program or your progress... Send

I'm a bot. For real humans: uplift@techunited.co

Give **before** you get.

Mentors who show up. Founders who share what's working, and what isn't. Peers who answer each other's questions before staff even sees them. None of that happens by accident. It happens because everyone in the room decided to give first.

Show up for each other the way you want people to show up for you.

"This is exactly what we needed. I'm a geneticist by training building a software company, with no business experience!"

• **Rachel Hayes**, *Founder, Ravel Genetics (Morrison cohort)*

Every founder leaves **with these five things.**

It's up to you to define what each of these means for you. In your portal, that's called Deep Work, a sentence or less per category. Not the answers below, just examples to get you thinking:



A stronger relationship

"A mentor I could actually text."



Greater clarity

"Should I go full-time on this?"



New resources

"Where do I find the right AI tools?"



A trusted mentor

"Someone with the scars to know what not to do."



A community

"Someone to tell when I'm having a bad day."

HOW TO SET YOURSELF UP FOR SUCCESS

WEEK 1 DEEP WORK · REQUIRED

To unlock your mentor, your Week 1 Deep Work asks you to define each of these five pillars and what they mean to you, beforehand, in a sentence or less. Take a moment in your portal to do so.

WEEK 2 ON · OPTIONAL

Short Deep Work prompts continue in your portal. Not required, but the more you put in, the more we can actually help.

Questions?

No question is too obvious. Chances are someone else has the same one.

QUESTIONS LATER IN THE PROGRAM

Reach us anytime at uplift@techunited.co

This contact is also available in your portal under the **Support** tab.

WHILE YOU'RE HERE, TWO MORE OPTIONAL THINGS

JOIN THE WHATSAPP

A peer group to ask each other questions.
Optional, not TechUnited-led.

AI DEMO NIGHT, SEPT 10

A bonus TechUnited event, not part of the
program. Free ticket: use code **UPLIFT**.

Your first action item: **get oriented.**

Attending onboarding is step one. Here's what to do next.

- **Get familiar with your portal.** Poke around. Find your cohort, find the resources.
- **Pass your onboarding quiz.** 10 questions, 10 out of 10, unlimited retakes. Every answer is in the onboarding deck in Resources.
- **Answer your Week 1 Deep Work questions.** Required, this is how we validate your mentor match. Deep Work becomes optional after Week 1.
- **Browse the educational sessions and register for the ones you already know you can make.** Lock those into your calendar now.
- **Download your AI note-taker.** Granola (preferred), Fathom, or Otter. Have it ready before your first mentor meeting.

Let's build a **better future,** together.

We're rooting for you.
Don't be a stranger.

Questions or need anything? Reach us at

UPLIFT@TECHUNITED.CO